THE BJP STRATEGY

- Separate Gen Z's genuine grievances from the CJP's political mobilisation; project the government as willing to listen, course-correct
- Put younger MPs and youth leaders at the forefront of a more targeted Gen Z outreach, with Instagram and reels replacing the party's old one-size-fits-all digital playbook
- Use the RSS's network of families, local groups, caste and regional networks to engage young voters beyond social media
- Pair political outreach with tangible responses on exam integrity, competitive-exam coaching, jobs and AI skills—while arguing that the BJP, rather than the CJP, can deliver results



"The sudden technological transformation has created a socio-cultural rupture, widening inter-generational communication gaps that we need to bridge as a society and as families. Otherwise, it will lead to social fragmentation"

— PRAFULLA KETKAR, *Editor,* Organiser

THE CONGRESS STRATEGY

- Defend the CJP's right to protest and support its demands. Don't attack it and alienate the Gen Z audience the party wants to reach
- Avoid any organisational compact with the CJP, which would confer legitimacy, cadres and national opposition status on it
- Strengthen Rahul's direct outreach to young people via 'Chhatron Ki Goonj', 'Ask Me Anything' and other interactive formats
- Compete more aggressively on youth issues, recognising that who delivers the message and how matters as much as the issue itself



"The Congress has asked the CMs of party-ruled states to prepare concrete plans for restructuring their education and examination systems. They will consult education experts, student bodies and other stakeholders and submit their plans within a month"

— K.C. VENUGOPAL, *MP & AICC Gen. Secy (Org.)*

vision. Unlike JP's call for *Sampoorna Kranti*, he says, "As of today, it's not there... I am not able to see it." The leadership question, in other words, circles back to the agenda. Before the CJP finds its JP, it may need to find its big idea.

Is this a Gen Z Moment?

The strongest wind in the CJP's sails may be the one that it did not create: a widening generational fault line in Indian politics. According to Congress ideologue and Rajya Sabha MP Praveen Chakravarthy, unlike Mandal or IAC, where mobilisation crystallised around a defining issue, the divide emerging now may increasingly be one of age. "For the first time, we are seeing a complete age fault line in Indian politics. Younger voters are not merely angry about jobs or examinations; they are increasingly impatient with an entire political establishment they regard as dated."

That alienation is reinforced by a political generation gap that may itself be accelerating. Prafulla Ketkar, editor of the RSS mouthpiece *Organiser*, argues that what once took 20-25 years to constitute a generational shift can now happen in four or five years, driven by technology and rapidly changing worldviews. "The sudden technological transformation," he says, "has created a socio-cultural rupture, widening inter-generational communication gaps that we need to bridge as a society and as families. Otherwise, it will lead to social fragmentation, leaving us without finding lasting solutions to the concerns that preoccupy data-defined Gen Z."

Intriguingly, even the CJP's ideological opponents acknowledge the danger of established politics failing to listen to this new constituency. As Ketkar points out, "Gen Z increasingly demands dialogue rather than one-way communication. They want to be listened to as well. They have their own concerns." K. Annamalai, former president of the BJP in Tamil Nadu, who left the party to form a grassroots organisation, argues that the BJP's increasingly insular system failed to detect the CJP groundswell and says the party must implement a genuine rather than a cosmetic generational renewal.

Yet discontent with old politics alone will not be enough to translate into allegiance to the CJP. It does not point to any cohesive "Gen Z vote". India's regional, caste and party structures remain powerful, and a successful movement can easily become an unsuccessful political party. Moreover, the CJP is not operating in a political vacuum. The BJP and Congress are already adapting their youth outreach (see box on BJP and Congress strategy). Established parties can adapt, rejuvenate their leadership, appropriate Gen Z issues and learn their digital language.

That is the paradox of the political milieu the CJP has entered: the environment may be unusually ripe for disruption without necessarily being ripe for the CJP. A generation may indeed be looking for something new, but whether the CJP can become its vehicle will depend on its ability to turn the fleeting advantages of youth and novelty into trust, performance and staying power. Season 1 showed that the CJP can make noise. Season 2 will tell us whether it can make change. ■